Chapter 2: The Architectural History of the Taj Mahal

While the idea of building a mausoleum on a grand scale for one's wife was a new one in the Mughal context, and the eventual building was remarkable for its scale and beauty, the architecture itself was not unprecedented but instead (like all Mughal architecture) a fusion of numerous Asian architectural and aesthetic influences.[14]

The term "Mughal" comes from the same origin as the English term "Mongol", and the Mughals were certainly descendants of the notorious Central Asian nomadic warriors. As the Turkic-speaking Mughals swept into the subcontinent of India in the 16th century, their distant linguistic cousins were founding the Ottoman Empire in today's Turkey. Between these two great empires was the Persian Empire, which at that time was approaching the apex of its power under the Shiite, Turkic-speaking Safavid Dynasty. At this point, the great Muslim cities of Baghdad and Damascus were eclipsed by the cultural splendor of the Safavid city of Isfahan, and the Mughals, under this influence, came to speak not Turkish but Persian as the first language of the court. In the same way, the Safavids themselves were "Persianized" by the people they ruled.[15]

However, in addition to the Persian influence, the Mughals encountered a land that had its own traditions of architecture, art, philosophy, and courtly elegance. The Hindu world had possessed its own great empires, including that of Ashoka the Great, and the Mughals were influenced by their cultural traditions as well. Even today, the cultural remnants of this mingling of traditions continues in the Islam practiced in India, Pakistan and Afghanistan, as well as the Urdu language of Pakistan, which all show deep influences of the Central Asian nomadic invasions, the Arab tradition of the Qur'an, the poetic and artistic practices of Persia and the ancient indigenous practices of South Asia[16].

Muslim Influences

At its core, the Taj Mahal is a Muslim building, something so obvious even to casual observers that many inquire whether it is a mosque. The central dome surrounded by spindly towers, and the obvious Muslim influences on the grand front gate, all seem to evoke an iconic image of a grand mosque with its